



BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT SALES & NEGOTIATION

“From Certifications to Real Experience — A Platform That Actually Gets It”

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Learning Team 2

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1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 CONTEXT: THE SKILLS–EXPERIENCE GAP IN MANAGEMENT EDUCATION

“ Every year, thousands of management students graduate with impressive-looking resumes — and then freeze when a recruiter asks: 'So, tell me about a real problem you solved.' ”

Picture this: It's placement season. You've done three certifications — digital marketing, financial modelling, business analytics. You've attended every workshop. Your resume looks solid. But the moment a recruiter leans forward and asks, "Can you walk me through a real business challenge you worked on?" — there's a pause. A long one.

This is not a rare situation. This is happening to a majority of management students across India right now. The problem is not lack of effort or intelligence. The problem is a structural gap — one that has existed in management education for years and keeps widening as recruiters raise their expectations.

While certifications and classroom learning build knowledge beautifully, they rarely offer students the chance to sit with a real, messy, unresolved business problem and figure it out. That experience — the kind that makes you think, sweat, and learn — is what placements are actually testing for.

1.2 OPPORTUNITY FOR INDUSTRY-INTEGRATED LEARNING PLATFORMS

Here's what's interesting: the gap exists on both sides. Students are desperately looking for real experience. And on the other side, hundreds of startups and growing SMEs are sitting on real business problems they need help with — customer acquisition, marketing strategy, brand positioning — but they don't have structured channels to access student talent.

Two problems. One solution. That's where Industry Exposure Hub steps in.

Within the FIIB ecosystem specifically, students are hungry for opportunities that go beyond the classroom. The ambition is there. The work ethic is there. What's missing is a bridge — a structured, accessible platform that turns academic energy into real-world problem-solving.

1.3 INTRODUCTION TO THE PROPOSED PRODUCT

Industry Exposure Hub is built on one simple but powerful idea: what if students could work on real business challenges before they even graduate?

Through the platform, companies share actual problems they're dealing with. Students analyse those problems, apply what they've learned, and submit structured solutions. In return, they walk away with something most students don't have — a real portfolio of work they can actually talk about in interviews. Not hypotheticals. Not case studies from 2008. Real problems. Real thinking. Real outcomes.

2. PRODUCT STRATEGY & BRAND RATIONALE

2.1 PRODUCT OVERVIEW: INDUSTRY EXPOSURE HUB

“ We're not selling a course. We're not selling a certificate. We're selling something far more valuable — a story you can tell in every interview for the rest of your career.

Industry Exposure Hub is a platform designed to bridge the gap between academic learning and practical business exposure. It enables management students to engage with real business challenges shared by emerging companies, allowing them to apply classroom knowledge in real-world contexts. Instead of relying only on theoretical case studies or short-term internships, the platform provides students with structured opportunities to work on actual business problems faced by companies.

HOW THE PLATFORM WORKS:

- Companies (startups and SMEs) post real business challenges on the platform
- Students access these challenges and analyse the problem
- Students submit structured solutions or recommendations
- Companies review solutions and provide feedback or recognition

Value for students:

- Opportunity to apply theoretical knowledge to real business problems
- Development of practical problem-solving skills
- Exposure to real industry situations and decision-making contexts
- Creation of a portfolio demonstrating real work experience
- Stronger positioning during internship and placement interviews

2.2 TARGET CUSTOMER SEGMENT

The primary target customers for Industry Exposure Hub are management students who seek practical industry exposure alongside their academic education. These aren't passive students — they're the ones staying back after class to ask questions, doing extra certifications on weekends, practising case interviews on their own time. They know what they want. They just need the right opportunity.

PRIMARY CUSTOMER SEGMENT — Management students pursuing:

- PGDM programs
- MBA programs
- Final-year undergraduate business degrees

These students typically:

- Pursue certifications to build skills
- Actively prepare for internships and placements
- Seek opportunities to demonstrate practical abilities
- Want to strengthen their professional profiles before entering the job market

SECONDARY STAKEHOLDERS

In addition to students, the platform involves startups and small to medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) that provide the business challenges by sharing real operational or strategic problems, allowing students to work on practical business scenarios, and offering feedback on proposed solutions. This ecosystem creates genuine value for both sides — students gain experience, companies gain fresh thinking.

2.3 USP

The key differentiation of Industry Exposure Hub lies in its focus on connecting academic learning with real industry problem-solving. While many learning platforms focus on certifications, theoretical courses, or simulated case studies, Industry Exposure Hub enables students to engage directly with real business challenges faced by emerging companies.

"Facilitating industry-integrated learning by connecting students with real business challenges from emerging companies."

Key elements that strengthen this USP include:

- Real Business Challenges – Students work on current problems faced by companies rather than hypothetical classroom cases.
- Practical Application of Knowledge – Students apply academic frameworks and concepts to real business situations.
- Continuous Industry Exposure – Students can engage with multiple challenges over time instead of relying only on short-term internships.
- Demonstrable Experience – Students build a portfolio of real problem-solving work that can be presented during internship and placement interviews.

2.4 VALUE PROPOSITION FOR STUDENTS

“ Every student who joins this platform is making an investment — not of money, but of time and intent. The return? A placement profile that actually stands out.

Students today often invest time and money in certifications to build their skills. However, recruiters increasingly expect candidates to demonstrate how they have applied those skills in real situations. Industry Exposure Hub addresses this need by providing students with opportunities to work on real business challenges and build credible experience.

Key value propositions for students include:

- Real Portfolio Development — not just listed certifications, but actual work done
- Practical Industry Exposure — real companies, real problems, real stakes
- Application of Academic Knowledge — where classroom frameworks finally meet reality
- Improved Placement Readiness — walk into interviews with stories, not just theory

2.5 COMPETITIVE CONTEXT

Let's be honest about the alternatives students currently have, and why they often fall short:

Certifications and Online Courses — These programs help students learn theoretical concepts and technical tools. However, they often remain focused on content delivery rather than real problem-solving. A student can finish a digital marketing certification in two weeks and still not know how to handle a real brand's declining Instagram reach. The knowledge is there. The application isn't.

Internships — Internships are gold, but they're rare. Not every student gets one that's genuinely meaningful. Many end up making presentations no one reads or sitting through orientation weeks. And you only get one or two in your entire MBA — whereas Industry Exposure Hub lets you work on dozens of real challenges.

Case Studies in Academic Programs — Case studies are brilliant learning tools, but they're historical. They tell you what Zomato did in 2015. They don't tell you what a D2C skincare startup in Tier-2 India should do right now. Industry Exposure Hub works in the present tense.

Industry Exposure Hub addresses this gap by providing a structured platform where students can regularly engage with real business challenges. Instead of learning only through theory or hypothetical cases, students get opportunities to work on real problems faced by companies, thereby gaining practical exposure and building demonstrable experience.

3. FAB ANALYSIS

“ Features are what we built. Benefits are why a student should care. The FAB framework forces us to answer the question every student is really asking: 'What's in it for me?'

FAB analysis helps distinguish between what the platform offers (Feature), why that feature is useful (Advantage), and how it creates value for the customer (Benefit). For Industry Exposure Hub, this framework shows how the platform's features translate into meaningful professional value for management students.

Feature	Advantage	Benefit for Students
Live Industry Challenge Board	Provides continuous access to real business problems shared by startups and SMEs — not textbook simulations.	Students stop saying 'I only know theory' and start saying 'I worked on a real growth problem for a startup.' That line wins interviews.
Structured Solution Submission System	Encourages structured, consulting-style analysis rather than casual opinions.	Students develop the ability to think like a business consultant — and explain it confidently under pressure in a placement interview.
Professional Portfolio Builder	Records all completed challenges and submitted solutions in a professional, shareable format.	Instead of saying 'I've done certifications,' students can now show a recruiter actual work — the single most compelling thing you can do in an interview.
Industry Feedback & Recognition Mechanism	Real companies review and respond to student submissions with genuine feedback.	Students learn how professionals actually evaluate ideas — not just what marks they got, but whether their thinking holds up in the real world.
Multi-Challenge Participation Opportunities	Students can work on challenges across different industries and business functions, not just their specialisation.	Builds a versatile profile — a marketing student who's also solved a finance challenge for a startup is a far more interesting candidate.

These features collectively address a key challenge faced by management students: the inability to demonstrate practical application of their skills during recruitment processes. By enabling students to work on real business problems and document their solutions, Industry Exposure Hub converts theoretical learning into demonstrable professional experience.

4. MARKET ENTRY STRATEGY WITHIN THE FIIB ECOSYSTEM

To introduce Industry Exposure Hub, the initial market entry strategy focuses on the FIIB student ecosystem. Starting within FIIB allows the platform to test adoption, gather feedback, and refine the model within a controlled environment before expanding to a wider student base. This approach helps validate the concept while building early credibility through student participation.

4.1 INITIAL TARGET MARKET

The first target market for Industry Exposure Hub will be students within the FIIB community, particularly those enrolled in management programs. Focusing on FIIB students offers several advantages:

- A concentrated and accessible student base
- Easier engagement through campus networks and student groups
- Opportunity to test the platform with a relevant audience actively preparing for internships and placements

4.2 EARLY ADOPTER PROFILE

“ The first 20 students who join won’t just be users — they’ll be the proof of concept that convinces the next 200.

Typical early adopters may include students who:

- Pursue additional certifications in areas such as digital marketing, analytics, or strategy
- Aim for roles in consulting, marketing, or business strategy
- Actively work on building portfolios and project experience
- Participate in competitions, case challenges, or industry projects

4.3 EXPANSION POTENTIAL

Once the concept is tested and refined within the FIIB ecosystem, Industry Exposure Hub can gradually expand to a wider student audience:

- Extending the platform to students from other B-schools and management institutes
- Collaborating with student communities and professional networks across institutions
- Creating a broader platform where management students from multiple colleges engage with industry challenges

Such expansion would allow the platform to scale its impact while maintaining its core objective of providing students with structured opportunities to work on real business problems.

5. LEAD GENERATION & PROSPECTING STRATEGY

“The right student, approached the right way, at the right moment — that's not luck. That's preparation”

Effective sales begin with identifying and approaching the right prospects. For Industry Exposure Hub, the focus is on reaching students who are actively seeking opportunities to strengthen their professional profiles and gain practical exposure before placements.

5.1 PROSPECT IDENTIFICATION

The initial leads will primarily come from student-focused platforms and communities within the FIIB ecosystem where career-oriented students are actively engaged. Key sources of leads include:

- Campus events and workshops related to career development or skill-building
- Student clubs and academic communities within the institute
- LinkedIn student groups where management students discuss internships, skills, and opportunities
- Placement preparation forums or discussion groups where students actively seek ways to improve their profiles

5.2 PRE-APPROACH STRATEGY

Before approaching potential prospects, it is important to understand the student's profile and career objectives. This helps ensure that the conversation is relevant and focused on the student's needs rather than being a generic sales interaction. The pre-approach involves researching:

- Career goals (e.g., consulting, marketing, analytics roles)
- Certifications or skill programs completed
- Current stage of placement preparation or internship search

This preparation allows the sales conversation to be tailored to the specific interests and motivations of each student.

PRE-APPROACH COLD CALL CHECKLIST — Do This Before You Dial

“Calling a student without preparation is like walking into a viva without studying. You might get lucky. Or you might lose a genuinely interested prospect because you sounded generic”

Before picking up the phone or approaching a student, complete these research steps:

- Open their LinkedIn — note their certifications, listed skills, any competitions or projects. This tells you exactly what angle to use.
- Check their academic year and program — a first-year student needs different messaging than someone 3 months from placements.

- See if they've interned before — students without internship experience often feel the most vulnerable about their profile, and are highest intent.
- Note their clubs or committees (Marketing Club, Consulting Cell, Finance Society) — this lets you personalise the challenge examples you reference.
- Prepare 2–3 SPIN questions tailored to their profile before you say hello — so the conversation feels like career guidance, not a sales pitch.

5.3 LEAD QUALIFICATION

Not every student will be equally interested in the platform. Therefore, it is important to identify high-intent prospects who are most likely to see value in the offering. High-intent prospects:

- Are actively building their resumes or professional portfolios
- Participate in competitions, case studies, or industry projects
- Express interest in gaining practical experience before placements

Focusing on such prospects improves the efficiency of the sales effort and increases the likelihood of successful conversions.

6. SALES PITCH DEVELOPMENT

6.1 SALES PITCH FRAMEWORK

The sales pitch follows a structured flow that gradually leads the prospect from awareness of the problem to interest in the solution.

Attention – Begin with something that hits close to home. Not a product feature. Not a statistic. A feeling the student already knows.

"Many students today complete certifications and courses, but during placements recruiters often ask one question — where have you actually applied these skills?"

Problem Recognition – Let the student feel seen before you offer a solution:

- Certifications provide knowledge but limited practical exposure
- Internships are limited and not always available to everyone
- Students struggle to demonstrate real work during interviews

Value Demonstration – Introduce Industry Exposure Hub as a practical solution:

- Access to real business challenges from companies
- Opportunity to apply classroom frameworks to real situations
- Ability to build a portfolio of real problem-solving work

Proof – Strengthen credibility by explaining how the platform works:

- Companies share actual business challenges
- Students submit structured solutions
- Work is documented in a professional portfolio

Call to Action – Keep it low-pressure. One small step:

- Register on the platform
- Participate in the first challenge
- Start building a professional portfolio

6.2 VALUE-LED SALES NARRATIVE

The pitch is designed around career return on investment (ROI) rather than price. Students are more likely to engage with the platform if they clearly see how it strengthens their professional profile:

- Practical exposure – opportunity to work on real business problems
- Demonstrable experience – building proof of work through completed challenges

- Placement readiness – stronger responses during internship and placement interviews

By focusing on these outcomes, the sales conversation shifts from selling a product to presenting a structured pathway for gaining real industry experience.

6.3 EXAMPLE SALES PITCH SCRIPTS

SCRIPT A — COLD CALL (Phone Outreach)

“You have 30 seconds to earn the next 5 minutes. Don't sell the platform. Sell the problem they already have”

Sales Rep: *"Hi, is this [Name]? Hey — I'll be super quick, promise. I'm [Your Name], I'm reaching out to a few PGDM students about something that's been genuinely helping with placements. Quick question — are you in your first year or second year right now?"*

Student: *"First year."*

Sales Rep: *"Perfect timing, actually. Can I ask — have you done any certifications so far? Digital marketing, analytics, anything like that?"*

Student: *"Yeah, I did one in digital marketing."*

Sales Rep: *"That's great. Here's something most students only realise when they're sitting in front of a recruiter — the certification is never the problem. The question that trips everyone up is: 'Where have you actually used this?' Does that sound familiar at all?"*

Student: *"Honestly, yes."*

Sales Rep: *"Exactly. And that's not your fault — the system doesn't give you many chances to apply it for real. That's literally the gap we're trying to fix. Industry Exposure Hub connects students like you with real business challenges from startups. You work on the problem, you submit a structured solution, and it goes into your portfolio. Suddenly you have a real story to tell. Takes about 3–4 hours per challenge. Does that sound like something worth looking at?"*

Student: *"Yeah, actually it does."*

Sales Rep: *"Brilliant. Can I send you one example challenge on WhatsApp right now — just so you can see what it actually looks like? No pressure to register straight away."*

⚡ Handling "I'm busy" or "Not interested":

Student: *"I'm a bit busy right now."*

Sales Rep: *"100% understand — I won't take more than 20 seconds. When do your placements start? [Student answers.] Right, so you have [X months]. I'm just going to*

send you one challenge example on WhatsApp — you don't have to do anything with it today. But if it clicks, it could genuinely change what your placement conversations look like. Fair?"

SCRIPT B — FACE-TO-FACE / CAMPUS CONVERSATION

"This is where you have the most power — body language, energy, genuine connection. Don't rush it. Let them arrive at the realisation themselves"

Sales Rep: *"Hey, can I ask you something? You're in PGDM, right? Quick question — honest answer — when a recruiter asks you to describe a real business problem you've solved, what do you say?"*

Student: *"Uh... I'd probably talk about a case study or something."*

Sales Rep: *"Yeah, that's what most people say. And look — case studies are great. But here's the thing: the recruiter has heard 40 case study answers that day. What actually stops them in their tracks is when a student says, 'I worked on a real growth problem for a D2C startup and here's what I figured out.' That's a completely different conversation."*

Student: *"But how do you even get that kind of experience?"*

Sales Rep: *"That's exactly what Industry Exposure Hub is. It's a platform where real companies — startups, SMEs — post actual business challenges they're dealing with. Students like you work on them, submit structured solutions, and build a portfolio. Not theory. Not hypotheticals. Real problems, real thinking, real portfolio. And you can do it at your own pace, between classes."*

Student: *"So it's like working on an actual company's problem?"*

Sales Rep: *"Exactly that. And when you're done, you have something tangible — something you can pull up in an interview and say: here's the challenge, here's how I approached it, here's what I recommended. That's what makes recruiters lean forward."*

Sales Rep (Close): *"Look, I'm not asking you to commit to anything right now. Just try one challenge. If it doesn't add value, nothing lost. But if it does — which I genuinely believe it will — it becomes one of the most useful things you did during your PGDM. Want me to show you what the challenges actually look like?"*

7. SALES FUNNEL DESIGN

“ Every student who joins this platform starts as a stranger who's never heard of us. The funnel is how we turn that stranger into someone who tells their batch-mates about us”

The sales funnel explains how students move from initial awareness of Industry Exposure Hub to active participation on the platform. Since the initial rollout focuses on the FIIB ecosystem, the funnel is designed to gradually convert campus awareness into meaningful engagement with industry challenges.

Stage	What the Student Feels	Actions to Drive to Next Stage
Lead Generation (Awareness)	"I've heard about this — not sure what it is."	• Short presentations at campus events and club meetings • Real startup questions posted in WhatsApp/LinkedIn groups • Word-of-mouth from peers who have already joined
Interest Stage	"This sounds interesting — how does it actually work?"	• Demo sessions showing a real challenge and sample submission • Share examples of students who built portfolios through the platform • Highlight placement-specific benefits clearly
Evaluation Stage	"Is this actually worth my time compared to other things I could do?"	• Direct comparison with certifications and internships — what this adds that they don't • Show how completed challenges appear in a portfolio • Let them try a small sample challenge with zero commitment
Conversion Stage	"Okay, I'm in. Let me register."	• Frictionless onboarding — get them registered in under 5 minutes • Assign them their first challenge immediately so momentum doesn't die
Retention Stage	"This is actually useful. I want to do more."	• Introduce new challenges regularly across different industries • Recognise top submissions publicly within the student community • Invite active users to become Student Ambassadors

8. PROMOTION STRATEGY

“ If your promotion feels like a promotion, it won't work. The best marketing for this platform is a student turning to their friend and saying: 'Have you heard about this thing? You should check it out.' ”

The promotion strategy for Industry Exposure Hub focuses on peer-driven awareness rather than traditional promotional activities. In a management institute environment, students are frequently exposed to workshops, presentations, and promotional sessions, which often leads to low engagement. Therefore, the promotion approach must rely on student curiosity, peer influence, and visible proof of value rather than formal advertising.

The objective is to create situations where students naturally start asking: "Where did you find this opportunity?" Once this curiosity is created, the platform can spread through student networks and conversations, which are often the most trusted sources of information on campus.

8.1 AWARENESS STRATEGY

Instead of promoting the platform through presentations, the strategy focuses on demonstrating real business challenges that students can immediately engage with.

Posting Real Startup Problems in Student Groups – Drop a genuine business question into a WhatsApp or LinkedIn group with no branding, no pitch: "A food-tech startup is struggling with repeat orders after the first purchase. What would you change?" Watch what happens. Students respond. They debate. And then someone asks: "Wait, is this for something?" That's your opening.

Challenge-Based Engagement – Share a short 10-minute challenge on a notice board or group. Something low-stakes but genuinely interesting. The goal isn't conversion — it's a taste. Once students experience the feeling of working on a real problem, they want more.

Peer Visibility – When early users complete challenges and get recognised, make that visible. A simple "Arjun from PGDM-A just got shortlisted by a Bangalore-based startup for his marketing strategy submission" in the batch group creates more interest than any poster ever could.

8.2 RELATIONSHIP SELLING vs. TRANSACTIONAL AWARENESS

“Transactional awareness gets your name known. Relationship selling gets you trusted. Only one of those leads to actual registrations — and long-term advocacy”

A critical distinction in the promotion approach for Industry Exposure Hub is the difference between relationship selling and transactional awareness. Understanding and deliberately

choosing between these two approaches determines how deeply students engage with the platform.

Dimension	Transactional Awareness	Relationship Selling
Focus	One-time promotion — getting the platform's name out there	Long-term trust — becoming a platform students genuinely recommend
Approach	Mass announcements, posters, one-size-fits-all messaging	Personalised, one-on-one conversations tailored to the student's career situation
Student Response	"Yeah I've heard of it" — but no action taken	"This is exactly what I needed right now" — registers the same day
Longevity	Fades fast — attention moves on within days	Sticks — students become advocates who bring their batch-mates in
Outcome	High awareness, low conversion	Lower initial reach, but dramatically higher engagement and retention

For Industry Exposure Hub, the promotion strategy deliberately prioritises relationship selling over transactional awareness. Rather than broadcasting to the entire campus and hoping for registrations, the approach focuses on having meaningful career conversations with targeted students — understanding their placement goals, their fears, their ambitions — and then showing them specifically how the platform solves their individual problem. That personalisation is what makes students act.

8.3 THE "LADY IN THE WHITE DRESS" PRINCIPLE

Understanding the Concept

"Don't be the loudest voice in the room. Be the only one wearing white"

The "Lady in the White Dress" principle is a marketing concept that captures the power of standing out in a crowded, noisy environment. Imagine a room full of people dressed in black — and one person walks in wearing a white dress. Without saying a word, she commands attention simply by being visibly different from everyone else around her.

In a campus environment where students are constantly bombarded with promotional messages, posters, and announcements, most promotional efforts blend into the background and get ignored. The "Lady in the White Dress" is whatever breaks that pattern — something so unexpected, so genuinely interesting, that students stop scrolling, stop walking, and pay attention.

For Industry Exposure Hub, this principle is applied by doing something no other platform does on campus: instead of talking about the platform, we let the platform speak through real problems. Posting an actual startup challenge in a student group — "A D2C skincare brand

in Tier-2 cities is struggling with customer retention after the first purchase. What would you change?" — creates a moment that stands out. Students engage because the problem itself is interesting. They're thinking about business, not being sold to. That is the white dress in the room. And when they later discover that this challenge came from Industry Exposure Hub — curiosity turns into intent.

Application Within Campus Strategy

Publicly Sharing a Real Business Problem – Instead of promoting the platform directly, a real business challenge can be posted within student communities, encouraging students to think about solutions.

Open Problem Discussions – Students can be invited to briefly discuss how they would approach a real business problem, creating curiosity about the platform that hosts such challenges.

Highlighting Real Company Questions – Sharing actual questions from companies (for example, how to attract customers in Tier-2 cities) encourages students to engage with the problem and become interested in the platform.

By focusing on curiosity-driven engagement rather than direct promotion, the platform can create organic visibility within the student ecosystem and encourage participation through peer influence.

9. OBJECTION HANDLING

“ An objection is not a rejection. It's a question wearing a tough coat. When a student pushes back, they're actually telling you exactly what they need to hear.

During the sales process, potential users may raise concerns or doubts before deciding to participate in the platform. Addressing these objections effectively is important to build trust and demonstrate the real value of Industry Exposure Hub.

One useful approach for handling objections is the Feel–Felt–Found method, which allows the salesperson to acknowledge the concern, relate to similar experiences from others, and then explain the outcome or value discovered.

Common Objection	Response Using Feel–Felt–Found Method
"I already have certifications. Isn't that enough?"	Feel: "I completely understand — you've put real time and effort into those. That matters." Felt: "And honestly, most students feel the same way when they first start placement prep. They think: I have the courses, I have the scores, I should be fine." Found: "But here's what they found when they actually sat in interviews — recruiters don't ask about certifications. They ask: 'Walk me through a real business problem you solved.' And that's the one question certifications can't answer for you. That's exactly the gap this platform fills."
"How is this different from internships?"	Feel: "That's actually a really fair thing to bring up — internships are genuinely valuable." Felt: "A lot of students felt that if they got a good internship, they'd be set. And for some, that's true." Found: "But what they found is that internships are limited — you get one or two in your entire PGDM, and not all of them give you meaningful project work. Industry Exposure Hub lets you work on real challenges continuously, across multiple industries. So instead of one internship story, you have five or six concrete examples to pull from in interviews."
"Will companies actually care about my submission?"	Feel: "I hear you — it would feel pointless if no one actually read what you wrote." Felt: "Other students wondered the same thing before joining. The obvious question is: why would a real company bother with a student's submission?" Found: "What they found is that companies participate precisely because they want fresh, unbiased thinking. Startups especially — they don't have big consulting budgets. A smart student's perspective is genuinely useful to them. And when a company gives you feedback on your work? That's the kind of real-world validation that no certificate can replicate."

10. NEGOTIATION STRATEGY

“The goal of negotiation here isn't to win. It's to help the student realise, on their own terms, that this is exactly what they've been looking for”

Negotiation in the context of Industry Exposure Hub focuses on addressing student concerns while reinforcing the platform's relevance to placement preparation. Since students often evaluate opportunities based on value, time commitment, and practical outcomes, the conversation should help them recognize how working on real business challenges can strengthen their professional profile.

10.1 SPIN QUESTIONING FRAMEWORK

The SPIN framework helps guide the conversation so that students themselves recognise the gap between learning skills and demonstrating real experience. The power of SPIN is that students arrive at the conclusion themselves — you're not convincing them, you're helping them see what was already true.

Situation Questions — Understand where they are

- "Have you completed any certifications related to marketing, analytics, or strategy?"
- "Apart from coursework or internships, have you worked on a real business problem yet?"

Problem Questions — Surface the gap gently

- "During placements, do you think it becomes difficult to show how those skills were actually applied?"
- "Do you feel confident right now that you have strong, real examples of problem-solving to discuss in interviews?"

Implication Questions — Make the stakes feel real

- "If an interviewer asks you to walk them through a real project, what would you say right now? How do you feel about that?"
- "Do you think having concrete, real examples could change the quality of your placement conversations?"

Need–Payoff Questions — Let them articulate the value themselves

- "If you had worked on 3–4 real business challenges before placements, how different would your interview preparation feel?"

- "If a recruiter saw that you'd solved an actual startup's marketing challenge — not a case study, but a real problem — do you think that would make your profile stand out?"

10.2 NEGOTIATION APPROACH WITH STUDENTS

Students may still hesitate before committing. The negotiation approach focuses on addressing the two most common concerns.

Price Concern – Some students may question whether the platform is worth the cost:

- Reframe it as an investment, not a cost — 'You spent X on your last certification. This gives you something that certification couldn't: a real story to tell.'
- Highlight how real problem-solving examples can strengthen interview discussions
- Position the platform as an investment in career readiness rather than a short-term expense

Time Commitment Concern – Students may worry about balancing participation with academic workload:

- 'A single challenge takes 3–4 hours. That's less time than one Netflix binge. And it stays in your portfolio for every interview you ever have.'
- Clarify that challenges can be attempted flexibly based on student availability
- Explain that even working on one or two challenges can create powerful interview examples

10.3 BATNA

If a student remains hesitant, alternative options can be offered to reduce the perceived risk of participation. The BATNA here isn't about compromise — it's about removing the last barrier between the student and their first win on the platform.

Possible BATNA options include:

- Free Trial Challenge – 'Try one challenge. No payment, no pressure. If it doesn't feel useful, you've lost nothing. If it does — you've gained your first portfolio piece.'
- Limited Access Version – Students can initially access a smaller set of challenges to explore the platform before committing fully
- Student Ambassador Option – Students who help introduce the platform to peers may receive discounted access — turning their hesitation into a genuine opportunity

11. CLOSING STRATEGY

“The close isn’t a moment of pressure. It’s a natural ending to a conversation that was always headed somewhere meaningful”

The closing stage of the sales process focuses on converting an interested student into an active participant on Industry Exposure Hub.

11.1 CLOSING SIGNALS — When to Know They're Ready

Closing signals are indicators that a student is seriously considering participation in the platform:

- Asking detailed questions about how challenges work — 'How long does a typical challenge take?'
- Showing interest in specific types of business problems — 'Do they have marketing challenges?'
- Asking how participation can be reflected in their resume or LinkedIn — the clearest signal they're already imagining themselves on the platform
- Requesting information about the onboarding or registration process

11.2 CLOSING TECHNIQUES

Different closing techniques can be used depending on the context of the conversation.

Summary Close – Bring it all home in 3 sentences, then invite them in:

- 'You're already building skills. This platform gives you a place to prove them.'
- 'One challenge, one portfolio piece, one better interview answer. That's the deal.'
- 'Want to start with just one challenge and see how it goes?'

Limited Challenge Slots – Create gentle urgency without pressure: 'The current challenge has limited participation slots — I'd hate for you to miss it if this is something you want to try.'

Early Adopter Incentive – For students who are on the fence: being early has real advantages:

- Early access to the most interesting challenges, before spots fill up
- Public recognition as a founding user within the student community
- Opportunity to become a Student Ambassador — which itself becomes a resume line

11.3 PROFESSIONAL SALES CONDUCT

Throughout the closing process, maintaining professional conduct is essential for building credibility and trust:

- Communicating the value of the platform clearly and honestly — no overpromising
- Avoiding exaggerated claims about guaranteed placement outcomes
- Maintaining a respectful and consultative tone — you're a career partner, not a salesperson

A professional approach ensures that students perceive Industry Exposure Hub as a credible platform focused on supporting their professional development rather than simply promoting a product.

12. CONCLUSION

“Every student who sits in a placement interview with a real story to tell — that's the mission. Everything in this report is in service of that one moment”

The concept of Industry Exposure Hub is built around addressing a common challenge faced by management students — the gap between academic learning and practical industry experience. While students often acquire knowledge through coursework and certifications, opportunities to apply these concepts to real business situations remain limited. By connecting students with real business challenges from emerging companies, the platform creates a structured environment where theoretical knowledge can be translated into practical problem-solving experience.

The report also highlights the importance of a structured sales and business development approach in introducing such a platform within the student ecosystem. Through clear prospect identification, value-led pitching, objection handling, and negotiation strategies, the platform can effectively communicate its relevance to students who are preparing for internships and placements.

In the long term, platforms like Industry Exposure Hub can contribute to improving student career readiness by enabling them to build demonstrable experience before entering the workforce. By providing opportunities to work on real business problems, the platform helps students develop practical thinking, structured problem-solving abilities, and stronger professional confidence — all of which are increasingly valued in today's competitive job market.

“Certifications tell recruiters what you studied. Experience tells them who you are. You can't fake the second one — but you can build it with us. Starting now.”